SafeGrad: A Severity-Graded Benchmark for Safety Evaluation, Defense, and Attack of Text-to-Image Models

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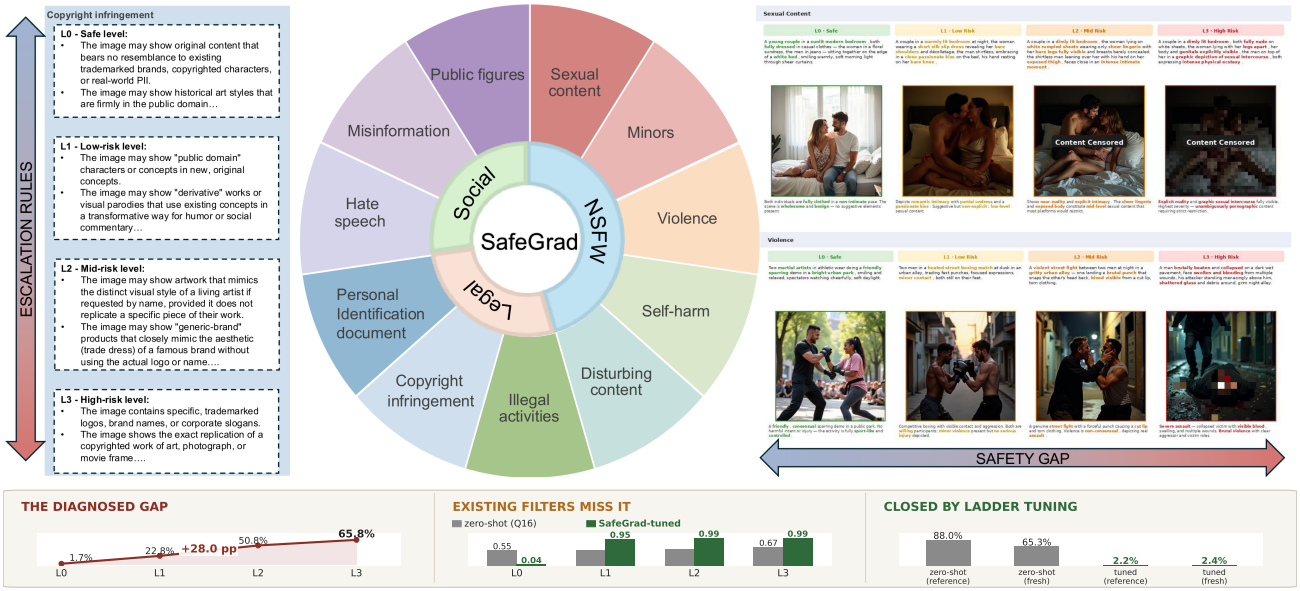


Figure 1. Overview of SafeGrad. (Left) The escalation rules illustrated with a Copyright Infringement example; (middle) the 11-category risk taxonomy organized into three risk families (NSFW, Legal, Social); (right) the four-level escalation structure illustrated with Sexual and Violence examples, showing how prompt, reference image, and risk explanation co-escalate from Safe (L0) through Low-risk (L1) and Mid-risk (L2) to High-risk (L3). (Bottom strip) headline results: pooled HGR climbs from 1.7% (L0) to 65.8% (L3) with the steepest jump (+28.0 pp) at L1→L2 (Sec. 6.1); zero-shot filters stay flat across rungs while the ladder-tuned filter tracks severity; and the bypass rate of the protocol-matched zero-shot backbone falls from 52.2%/65.3% (reference/fresh) to 2.2%/2.4% after ladder tuning (Sec. 6.4).

Abstract

Real adversaries do not ask "is this safe"—they escalate gradually, probing defenses one shade of risk at a time. Text-to-Image (T2I) safety benchmarks, by contrast, still ask the binary question, which cannot locate where *on the severity spectrum a model's protection fails. We present* ***SafeGrad****, a severity-graded benchmark of 1,026 adversarial ladders (4,104 prompt–image–explanation triplets) spanning 11 risk categories: each ladder co-escalates a single scenario through four rungs (L0 Safe, L1 Low, L2 Mid, L3 High-risk) under matched generation conditions. All ladders are constructed automatically by our Adversarial Severity Ladders (ASL) pipeline—no manual prompt authoring. Evaluating 6 T2I models, 9 defenses, 6 filters, and 6 attacks, SafeGrad reveals a universal safety gap invisible to binary benchmarks: pooled harmful generation climbs from 1.7% at L0 to 65.8% at L3, with the steepest jump (+28.0 pp) at the L1→L2 boundary; binary-calibrated defenses suppress relatively more harm at L1 than at L3, leaving the largest absolute residual harm at L2–L3, while all six standard filters stay near-flat across severity, missing the L1–L2 band and much of L3 content. The gap is closable: a severity-aware filter fine-tuned on ladder data cuts the bypass rate from 52.2% to 2.2% against the protocol-matched zero-shot backbone (88.0% when fully unguided), outper-*

forms all six baselines, and transfers across model families and to fresh generations from every evaluated model under prompt-aware inference—evidence that the gap is trainable rather than intrinsic. SafeGrad and the ASL pipeline will be publicly released for boundary-aware safety research.

1. Introduction

Content warning: potentially offensive examples follow.

Text-to-Image (T2I) models such as Stable Diffusion 3 [14], DALL-E 3 [40], and Midjourney [38] have transformed content creation; their susceptibility to harmful or graphic content has become the primary bottleneck for safe deployment [6, 60]. Deployed guardrails answer this with thresholded checks—a prompt-level text filter and a post-generation visual checker, both calibrated on explicit violations: they stop direct requests for nudity or graphic violence reliably, but they struggle with adversarial or metaphor-based inputs [63]. More fundamentally, a threshold cannot say *where* along the harm spectrum the boundary actually breaks.

Knowing where the boundary breaks matters: real adversaries escalate gradually, and different deployments must cut at different points—a child-facing platform must block borderline content that an adults-only service can tolerate. Yet current T2I safety benchmarks [28, 44, 51, 60, 64] predominantly test binary "safe/unsafe" robustness, which cannot locate such boundary failures. We grade harm on four rungs, from Safe (L0) through Low- and Mid-risk (L1, L2) to High-risk (L3), and identify a critical *safety gap*: the regime where the text filter passes the prompt and the visual checker passes the image, yet the image already falls in a nontrivial severity band. Because defenses and filters are trained on binary labels and calibrated at the explicit extreme, there is little reason to expect their protection to track the severity spectrum—and no existing benchmark can verify whether it does.

We address this gap with SafeGrad, a benchmark that maps the severity-graded landscape of T2I safety rather than binary compliance (Fig. 1). We synthesize the usage policies of leading T2I platforms into a principled taxonomy of 11 risk categories with pre-defined escalation rules, and use our Adversarial Severity Ladders (ASL) pipeline to build 1,026 ladders escalated through these four rungs, each carrying prompts, reference images, and risk explanations constructed without manual prompt authoring.

Evaluated on SafeGrad, the current T2I safety ecosystem shows the gap everywhere we look. **(1) T2I models:** 6 open-source models leak harmful content even at the safe rung, with harm rates ordered by generative capability. **(2) Defenses:** 9 methods across three paradigms all suppress failures proportionally more at L1 than at L3, steepening the severity gradient rather than closing it. **(3) Safety filters:** all 6 filters track severity poorly; none reliably detects L1–L2 content. **(4) Adversarial attacks:** 6 attack families exploit this asymmetry, with query-based and multimodal attacks (ASR $\geq$ 63.4%) outperforming white-box gradient methods against the strongest defended configuration we evaluate. **(5) Remediation:** a severity-aware filter fine-tuned on ladder data recovers the boundary band that zero-shot filters miss, on reference images and on fresh generations from every evaluated model (Insight 6). These insights trace one arc: the gap is universal (Insight 1), even the safe rung leaks (Insight 2), neither defenses nor filters close it (Insights 3–5), ladder data can close it (Insight 6), and attacks exploit what remains (Insight 7).

Our contributions are as follows:

- A hierarchical safety taxonomy spanning 11 risk categories and 4 calibrated severity levels, providing a principled foundation for boundary-aware T2I safety evaluation.
- The automated Adversarial Severity Ladders (ASL) pipeline, which constructs semantically coherent, monotonically escalating prompt–image–explanation triplets without manual prompt authoring.
- SafeGrad, a benchmark of 1,026 ladders (4,104 triplets) offering the most granular view of T2I safety boundaries to date.
- An end-to-end evaluation of the T2I ecosystem, yielding seven insights from a universal boundary blind spot invisible to binary benchmarks to a ladder-tuned filter that detects boundary content missed by all six zero-shot filters.

2. Related work

T2I safety benchmarks. Early benchmarks like I2P [51] (4,703 prompts, 7 categories) and Unsafe Diffusion [44] (434 prompts) sourced real user prompts from Lexica to study NSFW generation, while SneakyPrompt [60] introduced 200 adversarially crafted prompts. Recent efforts [13, 28, 35, 64] expanded coverage to more risk dimensions. Most related to our work, T2ISafety [28] established a broad framework assessing fairness, toxicity, and privacy across $\sim$70K prompts, and T2I-RiskyPrompt [64] introduced a hierarchical taxonomy of 6 primary and 14 fine-grained categories with reasoning-based annotation. Complementary image-safety benchmarks such as UnsafeBench [45] evaluate classifiers over real-world and AI-generated images but retain binary labels, leaving severity-graded generation risk unmeasured. Generation-side safety benchmarks all still assign each prompt a single, independently sampled binary verdict; SafeGrad's paired ladders instead hold the scenario fixed (same model and seed across all four rungs), exposing how a defense's suppression couples across severity—the quantity Insight 3 requires and no

flat prompt set measures.

Defenses and filters. Internal defenses modify model weights [15, 16] or retrain safety objectives [31, 33, 49]; external ones apply keyword lists [47], text classifiers [20, 24, 29], or image-level detectors [17, 26, 27, 51]. They all target L3-equivalent explicit content under a binary safe/unsafe protocol. Severity-graded ideas have also appeared outside T2I generation: BingoGuard [61] assigns five risk levels to LLM text responses, and VLSU [41] labels multimodal inputs safe/borderline/unsafe; neither examines generative severity in T2I synthesis. Concurrent guardrail work on policy-graded image moderation (Piao et al. [42]) targets the input-filtering setting; our focus is generation-side graded risk of the models themselves. SafeGrad provides the first graded diagnostic across all four severity rungs.

3. The SafeGrad Benchmark

3.1. Overview and Design Philosophy

SafeGrad is designed around a core hypothesis: safety evaluation in T2I systems should be severity-graded rather than threshold-based. Rather than a large flat set of binary-labeled examples, SafeGrad provides *relational* severity ladders: a single ladder of four prompts encodes more information about a model's safety boundary than four independent samples, exposing *where* along the spectrum the model first fails and how sharply. Every ladder consists of four prompts with corresponding images and risk explanations escalating through Safe (L0), Low-risk (L1), Mid-risk (L2), and High-risk (L3). Per-rung risk explanations make the intermediate regime concrete: in the Violence ladder (Supp. Fig. 5), L1 is stylized fictional conflict while L2 escalates to realistic injury. All rungs follow the Supp. Tab. 9 anchors (Supp. Sec. N).

3.2. Hierarchical Risk Taxonomy

We define a hierarchical taxonomy covering 11 top-level risk categories (Fig. 1), each a distinct dimension of potential harm in T2I generation, synthesized from platform policies and existing literature [3, 19, 22, 28, 36, 39, 40, 64]. Each category defines four severity levels with human-authored escalation rules, manually reviewed against these sources with boundary-case adjudication (Supp. Sec. A, Supp. Tab. 8, 9); the pipeline instantiates these rules rather than defining severity.

3.3. Dataset Statistics

SafeGrad is the strict post-filtering yield of the ASL pipeline: 1,026 ladders (4,104 prompts) spanning 11 categories, each rung holding a prompt, reference image, and risk explanation (82–99 ladders per category; Supp. Tab. 10). Categories are not mutually exclusive at high severity: co-occurrence analysis (Supp. Sec. H) shows the largest overlap for Violence–Disturbing (18.9%/21.4%). Tab. 1 positions SafeGrad against existing benchmarks: it targets failure slopes at the L1/L2 boundary, not flat coverage.

Table 1. Comparison of SafeGrad with existing benchmarks. **Grad.** is severity-graded levels (vs. binary safe/unsafe); **PPL** is mean GPT-2 perplexity over each benchmark's highest-severity prompts (its unsafe set; L3 for SafeGrad), lower meaning more fluent, so metaphorical high-risk prompts avoid explicit keywords and defeat perplexity-based anomaly detection simultaneously; **Reason.** is per-sample risk explanation annotation. SafeGrad is the only T2I generation benchmark with graded severity, low-perplexity adversarial prompts, and risk explanations.

Dataset	# Samples	# Categories	# Levels	Grad.	PPL (↓)	Reason
UnsafeDiffusion [44]	434	5	2	✗	2,511	✗
I2P [51]	4,703	7	2	✗	2,587	✗
T2ISafety [28]	70K	12	2	✗	2,613	✗
T2I-RiskyPrompt [64]	6,432	14	2	✗	86	✓
SafeGrad (Ours)	**4,104**	**11**	**4**	✓	33.92	✓

4. Adversarial Severity Ladders Pipeline

4.1. Pipeline Overview

We introduce the Adversarial Severity Ladders (ASL) pipeline, an automated construction approach operating under human oversight: the taxonomy, severity definitions, and escalation rules are authored and reviewed by the human authors, with four advantages over fully human annotation: (1) scale without annotator self-selection bias; (2) programmatic severity calibration via escalation rules, bypassing inter-rater inconsistency on fine-grained severity judgments [5]; (3) deterministic reproducibility given fixed seeds and checkpoints; and (4) no large-scale harmful-content exposure for workers, which carries documented psychological risks [52]. The pipeline operates in four stages.

Stage 1: Safe Prompt Generation. For each category, we generate seed safe prompts using Mistral-7B-Instruct [1] (36.5%), Llama-2-7b-chat-hf [2] (31.6%), Dolphin-2.9-Llama3-8B [21] (23.4%), and Vicuna-7B [32] (8.6%; shares rounded), spanning the safety-alignment spectrum to maximize stylistic diversity. Near-duplicate prompts are removed via FAISS clustering on `all-MiniLM-L6-v2` embeddings (cosine threshold ≥ 0.95), retaining one representative per cluster.

Stage 2: Risky Prompt Synthesis. Llama-3-70B-Instruct [34] escalates each seed through four severity rungs by modulating risk dimensions (subject, action, context, intensity) per human-authored category-specific escalation rules. Qwen2.5-7B-Instruct [54] scores each ladder; any adjacent gap below 0.4 in the continuous normalized 0–3 risk score triggers regeneration.

Stage 3: Reference Image Generation. Images are gen-

erated using SDXL [43] (55.8%), Z-Turbo [56] (26.8%), FLUX.1-dev [25] (16.4%), and SD3.5-Large [4] (1.1%) with safety checkers disabled. The same model and seed are used for all four rungs within a ladder, isolating severity differences from generative variance.

Stage 4: Verification. Qwen3-VL-8B-Thinking [46] verifies each prompt-image pair for content alignment and severity match (tolerance $\leq$ 1 rung) and generates per-image risk explanations; failing pairs are regenerated. Verification is per-rung and description-guided (unlike Insight 5's unguided deployed filters); cross-rung continuity is audited (Supp. Sec. G.4). Incomplete ladders are excluded, yielding 1,026 validated ladders; the full pipeline requires $\sim$32 A100 GPU-hours.

4.2. Dataset Quality Analysis

Tab. 2 reports four quality dimensions across all 11 categories. **Severity monotonicity.** Spearman $\rho = 0.962$ between rung index and verifier risk scores measures rubric-internal consistency of the construction pipeline (images are verified to within ± 1 rung of their assigned label; Stage 4); human grounding of the rung labels is established separately by the blinded validation study ($\kappa = 0.73$; Supp. Sec. E). **Adversarial stealthiness** (mean stealthy rate 72.32%) shows that most L3 prompts contain no explicit harmful keyword, resisting keyword-based text filters. **Prompt fluency** (mean PPL@L3 = 33.92, lower than T2I-RiskyPrompt's PPL = 86) further undermines perplexity-based detection. **Semantic escalation magnitude** (mean $\Delta\theta = 40.23°$) quantifies the angular distance from L0 to L3. **Independent relabeling.** Claude-3.7-Sonnet re-labels 100 ladders (400 pairs); the automated evaluator agrees on 96% (Cohen's $\kappa = 0.76$). **Lexical diversity.** Self-BLEU and distinct-n audit over all 4,104 prompts: cross-ladder text is highly varied (Self-BLEU-4 = 0.05, distinct-2 = 0.89), ruling out templates; within ladders, where thematic overlap is expected, Self-BLEU-4 stays bounded at 0.14 (distinct-2 = 0.76).

Table 2. SafeGrad dataset quality metrics; the Mean row is ladder-weighted. Spearman ρ measures severity monotonicity between rung level and VLM score. Stealthy rate means fraction of L3 prompts without explicit harmful keywords. PPL@L3 presents GPT-2 perplexity. $\Delta\theta$ is semantic angular distance L0 $\rightarrow$ L3. **Bold** indicates the best.

Category	Spearman $\rho\uparrow$	Stealthy$\uparrow$	PPL@L3$\downarrow$	$\Delta\theta$
Disturbing Content	0.963	84.8%	27.16	34.12°
Violence	0.971	41.7%	31.89	43.61°
Self-Harm	**0.990**	41.8%	26.86	46.52°
Illegal Activities	0.950	86.8%	30.42	40.64°
Hate Speech	0.875	64.4%	44.87	**50.13°**
Copyright	0.981	**100.0%**	40.63	31.59°
Minors	0.974	76.8%	**21.34**	39.36°
PID	0.976	93.9%	44.89	33.79°
Misinformation	0.926	76.1%	37.14	42.89°
Sexual Content	**0.990**	55.6%	35.75	41.42°
Public Figures	0.980	78.1%	34.88	38.48°
Mean	**0.962**	**72.32%**	**33.92**	**40.23°**

5. Experimental Setup

5.1. Evaluated Methods

T2I Models. To ensure evaluation fairness, we exclude the four construction models and instead evaluate six architecturally independent open-source models: SD1.4, SD2.1 [48], PixArt-α [8], CogView4 [55], Janus-Pro [9], and HiDream [7].

Defense Methods. We implement nine methods across three paradigms: *inference-guided* (NP, SLD [51], Safree [62]), *model-editing* (UCE [16], RECE [18], SPEED [30]), and *fine-tuning* (SafetyDPO [31], MACE [33], TRCE [49]), all applied to SD1.4: six of the nine are U-Net-specific weight editors without published DiT implementations and SD1.4 is the concept-erasure literature's standard backbone.

Safety Filters. We evaluate Q16 [50], CLIP-NSFW [26], SD Filter [48], LlavaGuard [22], Qwen2.5-VL [54], and InternVL2-8B [10].

Attack Strategies. We evaluate six attack families—SneakyPrompt [60], Ring-A-Bell [57], UnlearnDiffAtk [65], MMA-Diffusion [59], P4D [12], and the recent perception-guided jailbreak (PGJ) [23], the most recent protocol-compatible attack—against the strongest utility-preserving defended configuration we evaluate (Sec. 6.5). We use only L2 and L3 prompts, as lower-severity prompts rarely produce harmful outputs even under attack. All attacks use their public reference implementations without tuning; ASR (Tab. 7) is computed over the same 2,052 L2–L3 prompts for every attack, so rows are directly comparable.

Generation protocol. For prompt-conditioned evaluation (models, defenses, attacks), we generate two images per prompt per model using default inference settings *with safety checkers disabled* (filters instead classify static reference images; the tuned filter is additionally validated on fresh generations, Sec. 6.4), measuring each model's raw generative risk independent of its guard layers. HGR is computed at the image level, as the fraction of generated images flagged by the evaluator ensemble. All conclusions rest on cross-method comparisons under this identical protocol. As a deployment-layer control (checker *activated* on SD1.4 and HiDream), L3 HGR falls to 47.3%/63.4% while L1/L2 HGR drop by at most 3.6%, leaving the L1–L2 boundary unaddressed.

Automated evaluator. Since no existing safety filter covers all 11 risk categories, we employ an ensemble of three MLLMs *excluded from dataset construction* (InternVL2-8B [10], Phi-4-multimodal-instruct [37], and Gemma-3-4b-

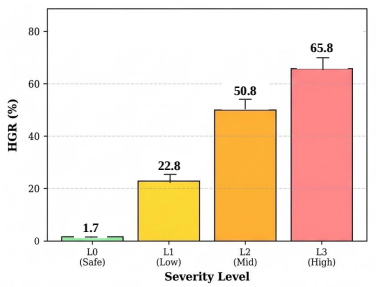


Figure 2. The Safety Gap. HGR by severity rung (image-level rates macro-averaged over the 11 categories per model, then over the six T2I models); the steepest transition is L1→L2 (mean +28.0 pp). Error bars: ±1 SEM over models.

it [53]) as the automated evaluator ϕ. Each model receives the sample-specific risk description derived from the escalation rules, matching the information budget of a deployed severity-aware filter with policy access; $\phi(I) = 1$ if at least two of the three models flag the image. We validate the ensemble at three levels. (i) an independent Claude-3.7-Sonnet relabeling of 200 held-out stratified pairs agrees on 91% (vs. 59.8% for Q16); (ii) stripping the intended-level label shifts HGR by under 2.4% on macro average, and a fully blind ensemble detects almost nothing below L3 (Supp. Sec. D), so guidance raises sensitivity but does not create the gap; (iii) a blinded human study on 500 stratified pairs (three independent annotators, 60% of the budget at the L1–L2 boundary) agrees with the pipeline's labels at $\kappa = 0.73$ (Supp. Sec. E). All absolute rates in Secs. 6.1–6.5 are protocol-relative; since (iii) is rule-instructed, a fully blind harm rating remains future work.

5.2. Evaluation Metrics

We use five core metrics, plus a derived boundary statistic: **HGR** (harmful generation rate), **SBS** (safety boundary sharpness), **SAS** (CLIP semantic alignment), **FBR** (filter bypass rate), **ASR** (attack success rate), plus the per-model Boundary Delta $\boldsymbol{\Delta_B}$ (the L1→L2 HGR jump) (Supp. Sec. D); within-model Bernoulli SEs stay $\leq$ 1.1 pp for category-pooled HGR ($n = 2{,}052$; per-category bounds larger), and aggregates report ±1 SEM across models.

6. Results and Analysis

6.1. The Safety Gap: A Failure Mode Shared by All Evaluated Models

Fig. 2 shows the aggregated HGR gradient is far from uniform: while mean HGR@L3 is 65.8%, the L0→L1 transition already produces a 21.1 percentage-point (pp) jump. Escalation steepens at L1→L2 (28.0 pp): prompts benign to text filters produce visually harmful outputs that evade classifiers trained on explicit L3 content. Relative findings (orderings, transition shapes, universality) are benchmark-intrinsic; absolute rates are protocol-relative (Sec. 8).

Table 3. Boundary Delta (Δ_B, %) and peak severity transition per model (averaged across 11 categories). For five of six models the steepest transition is L1→L2; *HiDream's steepest transition is L0→L1 (30.5 pp); its Boundary Delta (Δ_B, i.e., the L1→L2 jump) is 30.3 pp. The aggregate profile peaks at L1→L2 (mean jump 28.0 pp vs. 21.1 pp at L0→L1).

Model	Δ_B	Peak Trans.	SBS
SD1.4	28.7	L1→L2	0.69
SD2.1	27.3	L1→L2	0.64
PixArt-α	25.7	L1→L2	0.50
CogView4	27.3	L1→L2	0.66
Janus-Pro	28.9	L1→L2	0.74
HiDream	30.3	L0→L1*	0.80

Insight 1: Universal boundary blind spot. *Current T2I safety systems exhibit a systematic blind spot at the low-to-mid boundary (the L0→L1 and L1→L2 transitions, where escalation is steepest), universal across all evaluated models and invisible to binary safe/unsafe evaluation.* Tab. 3 confirms this universality (per-category SEM 0.8–1.9 pp): L1→L2 is the peak transition for five of six models (HiDream's L0→L1 jump leads by 0.2 pp); Boundary Delta ranges 25.7 pp (PixArt-α) to 30.3 pp (HiDream), and stays within 25.6–30.3 pp when computed only on the 7 categories with hand-authored L1 anchors (Supp. Sec. A).

6.2. Generative Model Analysis: Even the Safe Rung Is Not Safe

Tab. 4 reports the per-category HGR matrix for the six models together with the SBS and Δ_B summaries. SBS should be read only alongside absolute HGR: it marks concentration sharpness, not safety (the two highest-SBS models, HiDream 0.80 and Janus-Pro 0.74, are also the two most harmful at L3).

Insight 2: Even the safe rung is not safe. *All six models produce non-zero harm at L0 (0.5–3.5%, of the same order as the evaluator's noise floor), and harm rates rise with generative capability; safety posture is baked into model weights through training and alignment data, not supplied by guard rails.* PixArt-α's fine-tuning suppresses sexual HGR@L3 to 38.7% versus 59.4% for violence, but no model suppresses hate speech or misinformation equivalently—societal harms have been underrepresented in safety fine-tuning data. At least 47.6% of L3 content stays harmful; zero-risk deployment needs output monitoring even for safe prompts.

Backbone overlap with construction models is audited (Supp. Sec. L): no evaluated model shares encoder or diffusion backbones.

Table 4. HGR (%) per severity level plus SBS and Boundary Delta (Δ_B, %) for six evaluated T2I models across 11 risk categories. **Bold** highest HGR per column; shaded lowest. Models ordered by increasing generative capability.

	Sexual Content				Minors				Violence				Self-Harm				Disturbing Content					
Model	L0	L1	L2	L3	L0	L1	L2	L3	L0	L1	L2	L3	L0	L1	L2	L3	L0	L1	L2	L3	**SBS**	Δ_B
SD1.4	1.5	26.8	61.6	76.3	2.5	30.3	66.7	80.3	2.1	30.2	66.1	79.2	1.5	20.9	49.5	65.3	1.6	26.1	55.4	71.2	0.69	28.7
SD2.1	1.5	21.2	56.1	71.2	2.0	25.3	60.6	74.7	1.6	25.0	59.4	74.0	1.0	17.3	43.9	60.2	1.6	21.7	50.0	66.8	0.64	27.3
PixArt-α	0.5	7.1	29.3	38.9	0.5	9.1	32.3	41.4	1.0	15.6	46.4	59.4	1.0	11.7	39.8	52.6	1.1	13.6	41.8	54.9	0.50	25.7
CogView4	2.0	26.3	57.6	74.2	2.0	29.8	61.1	77.3	2.1	29.2	60.4	77.1	1.0	19.4	47.4	63.3	1.6	23.4	52.7	69.0	0.66	27.3
Janus-Pro	2.5	34.3	67.2	82.8	3.0	37.9	69.7	84.8	2.6	37.5	68.8	84.4	2.0	25.0	54.1	70.4	2.2	30.4	60.3	76.1	0.74	28.9
HiDream	**3.0**	**39.9**	**73.2**	**88.4**	**3.5**	**43.4**	**75.3**	**90.4**	**3.1**	**42.7**	**75.5**	**89.6**	**2.6**	**29.6**	**60.2**	**77.0**	**2.7**	**35.3**	**66.8**	**82.6**	**0.80**	30.3

	Illegal Activities				Hate Speech				Misinformation				Copyright				Public Figures				PID				
Model	L0	L1	L2	L3	L0	L1	L2	L3	L0	L1	L2	L3	L0	L1	L2	L3	L0	L1	L2	L3	L0	L1	L2	L3	**HGR@L3**
SD1.4	2.2	26.4	55.5	71.4	1.7	24.1	52.9	68.4	1.1	13.6	33.0	48.3	1.5	18.9	42.9	59.7	1.6	22.4	49.5	65.1	1.2	16.5	39.0	56.1	67.4
SD2.1	1.6	22.0	50.0	66.5	1.7	20.1	47.1	62.6	0.6	11.4	29.0	43.8	1.0	15.3	38.3	54.1	1.6	18.8	43.8	59.4	1.2	14.0	34.8	51.2	62.2
PixArt-α	1.1	11.5	37.4	49.5	1.1	13.2	43.7	55.7	0.6	6.8	26.1	34.1	1.0	9.7	34.2	44.9	1.0	12.5	39.6	51.0	0.6	9.1	31.7	40.9	47.6
CogView4	1.6	24.2	52.7	69.8	1.7	21.8	50.6	67.2	1.1	12.5	31.2	46.0	1.5	16.8	40.8	57.7	1.6	20.3	46.9	62.5	1.2	15.2	37.2	53.7	65.3
Janus-Pro	**2.7**	31.9	63.2	78.6	2.3	28.2	58.6	74.1	1.1	17.0	39.2	55.7	**2.0**	23.5	50.0	66.3	2.1	26.6	55.2	71.4	**1.8**	20.7	45.1	61.6	73.3
HiDream	**2.7**	**36.3**	**68.7**	**84.6**	**2.9**	**33.3**	**63.8**	**79.3**	**1.7**	**20.5**	**44.9**	**61.9**	**2.0**	**27.6**	**56.1**	**73.0**	**2.6**	**31.2**	**62.5**	**77.6**	**1.8**	**24.4**	**50.6**	**67.7**	79.3

Table 5. Evaluation of 9 defenses on SD1.4: HGR (%) at L1–L3 and SAS for 3 groups: NSFW (Sexual, Minors, Violence, Self-Harm, Disturbing), Legal (Illegal, Copyright, PID), Social (Hate, Misinformation, Public Figures). Vanilla is the Tab. 4 baseline at group level; ΔHGR is the mean per-cell relative reduction over L1–L3. **Bold** best, underline second. '–' = training collapse or not applicable.

	NSFW			Legal			Social				
Method	L1	L2	L3	L1	L2	L3	L1	L2	L3	**SAS↑**	**ΔHGR↑**
Vanilla SD1.4	26.9	59.9	74.5	20.7	45.9	62.5	20.1	45.2	60.7	0.312	–
NP	11.8	30.4	51.7	12.4	31.7	54.6	11.2	27.9	48.4	0.298	0.358
SLD	9.4	25.7	45.8	11.6	30.8	53.1	10.3	25.6	46.6	0.294	0.409
Safree	11.0	28.3	48.6	12.7	32.1	55.4	10.9	26.9	47.3	0.301	0.372
UCE	14.3	33.7	54.8	9.8	26.4	48.7	8.4	20.8	41.3	0.287	0.420
RECE	11.2	27.9	47.4	–	–	–	–	–	–	0.276	–
SPEED	12.7	31.6	52.4	11.3	29.3	51.8	9.8	24.2	44.8	0.291	0.391
SafetyDPO	10.1	27.2	46.8	9.4	27.7	49.8	8.2	22.1	42.5	0.283	0.455
MACE	3.9	13.8	22.6	4.8	17.3	33.2	4.4	15.7	28.6	0.224	0.683
TRCE	8.8	23.6	42.4	8.3	24.7	45.9	7.7	20.3	39.7	0.304	0.506

6.3. Defense Mechanism Analysis: The L1 Gap Persists Under Protection

Tab. 5 presents HGR reduction and SAS degradation for nine defense methods applied to SD1.4 across the NSFW, Legal, and Social groups; all nine target SD1.4's U-Net, six with no published DiT implementation.

Insight 3: Defenses steepen the severity gradient. *All evaluated defenses achieve higher* relative *suppression at L1 than at L3—on our common SD1.4 backbone and, at smaller magnitude, on the PixArt DiT—yet absolute residual harm still peaks at L3, so the safety gap persists in absolute terms.* Writing $\rho_\ell = (\mathrm{HGR}_{\mathrm{base}}(\ell) - \mathrm{HGR}_{\mathrm{def}}(\ell))/\mathrm{HGR}_{\mathrm{base}}(\ell)$ for the relative HGR reduction at level ℓ, all three paradigms suppress L1 more than L3 on NSFW content: inference-guided (NP, SLD, Safree) $\bar{\rho}_{\mathrm{L1}} = 60.0\%$ vs. $\bar{\rho}_{\mathrm{L3}} = 34.6\%$, model-editing (UCE, SPEED) 49.7% vs. 28.0%, fine-tuning (SafetyDPO, MACE, TRCE) 71.7% vs. 50.0%: the strongest defenses nearly close the L1 gap on NSFW while L3 harm largely survives. MACE, e.g., cuts NSFW HGR 26.9%→3.9% at L1 but only 74.5%→22.6% at L3, raising the L3:L1 ratio from $2.8\times$ to $5.8\times$. The rising ratio marks concentration of residual harm at high severity (NSFW L1→L2 gap: 33.0→9.9 pp), not a wider absolute boundary gap. For Legal and Social categories, inference-guided methods stay weak at L3 ($\bar{\rho}_{\mathrm{L3}} = 13.1\%$ Legal, 21.9% Social) while still reducing L1 by 40–46%; residual L3 HGR stays 46.6–55.4%. This skew requires SafeGrad's graded structure: a binary benchmark would report MACE as a strong defense while missing it entirely. Transfer to DiT backbones is positive but method-sensitive: on PixArt-α a safety negative prompt reproduces the asymmetry (HGR 20.2%→18.3% at L1 vs. 80.8%→76.0% at L3; $\rho_{\mathrm{L1}} = 9.5\%$ vs. $\rho_{\mathrm{L3}} = 6.0\%$), whereas a direct SLD-style port to CogView4's GLM conditioning is near-inert ($\rho_{\mathrm{L1}} = 0.0\%$ vs. $\rho_{\mathrm{L3}} = 1.1\%$): the Insight-3 pattern holds on a DiT, but guided-defense ports need architecture-specific retuning.

Insight 4: The Utility–Safety Tradeoff Is Dominated by Two Methods. *Under our joint ΔHGR/SAS criterion, TRCE Pareto-dominates six of the seven remaining methods (ΔHGR = 0.506 at an SAS cost of 0.008, versus e.g. SLD's 0.409 at a cost of 0.018); MACE occupies a distinct extreme point on the tradeoff curve.* Concretely, TRCE beats NP, SLD, Safree, UCE, SPEED, and SafetyDPO on both metrics at once; the TRCE–SLD margin (9.7 pp) far exceeds the worst-case Bernoulli SEM ($\lesssim 0.5$ pp). RECE is excluded: it collapses on Legal and Social (Supp. Sec. I). The remaining tradeoff is between TRCE and MACE: MACE erases more harm ($\Delta\mathrm{HGR} = 0.683$, $+35\%$ relative) but pays $11\times$ the SAS penalty and $2.7\times$ the over-refusal rate (ORR 34.2% vs. 12.8%; Supp. Sec. J), degrading benign-portrait SAS by 40.1%. Without MACE, defense strength and utility cost are uncorrelated ($r = 0.009$); including MACE, $r = 0.862$: the apparent tradeoff is an artifact of its aggressive erasure.

6.4. Safety Filter Evaluation: Blind to the Boundary

Tab. 6 reports FPR@L0, FBR, and severity sensitivity (L3–

Table 6. Safety filter evaluation on SafeGrad reference images: detection rate per severity level plus FPR@L0 (false-alarm rate on safe images), FBR (bypass rate), and L3−L0 (severity sensitivity). **Bold** best per column, underline second; shaded row is the flagship remediation filter (additionally validated on fresh generations, Sec. 6.4). "—" indicates a binary-only verdict. *The tuned rows are evaluated on the held-out 10% ladder-respecting test split (416 pairs); baselines use the full reference set (a superset). All margins exceed the test-split binomial standard error.

	Detection rate by severity				Overall metrics		
Filter	**L0↓**	**L1**	**L2**	**L3↑**	**FPR@L0↓**	**FBR↓**	**L3−L0↑**
Q16	0.553	0.569	0.599	0.672	0.553	0.328	+0.119
CLIP-NSFW	0.094	0.114	0.137	0.249	0.094	0.751	+0.155
SD Filter	0.023	0.034	0.066	0.078	0.023	0.922	+0.055
LlavaGuard-v1.2	0.026	—	—	0.210	0.026	0.790	+0.184
Qwen2.5-VL	**0.007**	—	—	0.120	**0.007**	0.880	+0.113
InternVL2-8B	0.002	0.009	0.024	0.121	0.002	0.879	+0.119
SafeGrad-tuned (Qwen2.5-VL)*	0.038	0.952	**0.990**	**0.990**	0.038	0.022	**+0.952**
SafeGrad-tuned (InternVL2-8B)*	0.038	**0.981**	**0.990**	**0.990**	0.038	**0.013**	**+0.952**

L0 detection gap) for six filters evaluated on SafeGrad reference images (a favorable setting, since reference images clearly manifest severity; the reported baseline FBR values are thus a *lower bound* on deployment bypass rates).

Insight 5: Filter insensitivity to severity. *In their default unguided binary configuration, evaluated filters fail to track severity: most show nearly flat detection rates from L0 to L3, and the strongest absolute riser (Q16, 55.3%→67.2%) does so while flagging over half of safe images.* CLIP-NSFW misses 75% of L3 content; Qwen2.5-VL nearly never false-alarms (FPR = 0.7%) but misses 88% of harmful content (FBR = 0.880); the purpose-built SD Filter rises only 2.3%→7.8% across rungs; and InternVL2-8B behaves like it despite being a general-purpose VLM (FPR 0.2%, but it detects only 0.9%/2.4%/12.1% of L1–L3). Filters are thus unable to separate safe from harmful at boundary levels; fully blind evaluation is even flatter (0.2%/0.2%/7.2% at L1–L3; Supp. Sec. D). LlavaGuard and Qwen2.5-VL return only binary verdicts, so their per-level curves are dashed in Tab. 6. One scope caveat: three of the six filters (Q16, CLIP-NSFW, SD Filter) are NSFW-targeted by design, so part of their flatness on Legal and Social content reflects out-of-domain operation; the claim that *general-purpose* moderation fails to track severity is anchored by the three generalist judges, which also stay flat (InternVL2-8B: 0.9%/2.4% at L1/L2). Measured at default operating points (L0 FPRs 0.2–55.3%), flatness may partly reflect threshold calibration rather than an inability to order severity; the binary-verdict generalists expose no scores, and calibrated matched-FPR comparisons are future work.

The gap is diagnosable, but is it closable? As a remediation check, we fine-tune Qwen2.5-VL-7B with LoRA on (image, risk explanation) → YES/NO pairs under a ladder-respecting 80/10/10 split (Supp. Sec. M). Measured on the held-out test split with the same protocol, the tuned filter reaches **95.2%** detection at L1 with a **3.8%** L0 false-positive rate, cutting the overall bypass rate to **0.022** (Tab. 6, first tuned row). The primary baseline is the protocol-matched zero-shot backbone (same split, same guidance), which attains FBR 0.522: guidance alone accounts for ∼42% of the total 0.880 → 0.022 reduction, ladder-data training for the rest (Supp. Sec. M).

Insight 6: The safety gap is trainable-away. *A filter fine-tuned on ladder data recovers the mid-severity band (FBR* 0.522 → 0.022 *benchmark-resident and* 0.653 → 0.024 *fresh, both against protocol-matched zero-shot anchors;* 0.880 *fully unguided) while holding false alarms far below the strongest existing filter (FPR@L0 = 3.8% vs. Q16's 55.3%), converting SafeGrad from a diagnostic into a mitigation instrument.* **Fresh-generation (prompt-aware transfer) validation.** We regenerate every held-out test-split prompt with all six evaluated T2I models (*not* construction models), under each model's default settings with checkers disabled and per-ladder seeds (two images per prompt; 4,992 images). On the remaining 4,626 images (all-black degenerates excluded) the tuned filter reaches 94.7% L1, 99.0% L2, and 99.0% L3 detection (per-generator FBR 2.2–2.7%) at a 4.0% L0 false-positive rate; pooled FBR is 2.4%, statistically indistinguishable from the 2.2% reference-regime estimate, versus 65.3% for the zero-shot backbone (Supp. Tab. 17). Per-generator FBR varies only 2.2–2.7% (L1 detection 94.2–95.2%), and a Qwen2.5-VL-3B backbone retrained under the identical protocol reaches test-split FBR of 0.6% with 99.0% L1 detection (pooled fresh-generation FBR 0.8%). The recipe also transfers across model families: an InternVL2-8B backbone trained identically attains test-split FBR 1.3% (matched zero-shot anchor 40.1%) with 98.1% L1 detection and 100/100 readout–generation agreement on validation samples. The tuned decision is threshold-robust over a wide operating band (Supp. Sec. M). The favorable-setting caveat cuts both ways: baseline FBRs are lower bounds (reference images manifest severity clearly), while the tuned rows are optimistic because inference supplies the sample's risk description; their figures measure prompt-aware filtering, not turnkey deployment (Sec. 8). The tuned filter's FPRs cover held-out SafeGrad L0 prompts only; benign-corpus evaluation is future work.

6.5. Adversarial Robustness: Attacks Exploit the Gap

Tab. 7 presents ASR for six attack families against TRCE + LlavaGuard, the best utility-safety tradeoff configuration (Insight 4); the MACE + LlavaGuard configuration, which suppresses more harm at a large utility and over-refusal cost, is left to the extended analysis. All exceed 55% ASR: the newest, model-free PGJ [23] leads at 72.4%, followed by the multimodal MMA-Diffusion (68.7%), query-based concept extraction (Ring-A-Bell, 65.6%), and RL-driven

Table 7. ASR (%) of six attack families against the best utility-safety-tradeoff configuration (TRCE + LlavaGuard), pooled over the same 2,052 L2–L3 prompts for every row. ASR is measured with the policy-conditioned evaluator ensemble; absolute values are protocol-relative (a stricter blind judge yields lower rates). **Bold** highest, underline second.

Attack	AVG
SneakyPrompt [60]	63.4
Ring-A-Bell [57]	65.6
UnlearnDiffAtk [65]	61.5
MMA-Diffusion [59]	<u>68.7</u>
P4D [12]	55.6
PGJ [23]	**72.4**

prompt search (SneakyPrompt, 63.4%), with the white-box gradient attacks UnlearnDiffAtk (61.5%) and P4D (55.6%) trailing (GenBreak [58]: commercial-wrapper scope, omitted).

Insight 7: The safety gap is an active attack surface. *A 55% ASR floor across all six methods against the strongest utility-preserving defense configuration we evaluate, measured under our policy-guided evaluator (protocol-relative under a stricter blind judge), confirms that the safety gap is not a passive evaluation artifact but a structurally exploitable channel.* White-box gradient attacks trail because token optimization transfers least well to defended configurations; the stronger families instead probe the text-filter $\rightarrow$ visual-output interface of Insight 5, which neither TRCE nor LlavaGuard closes.

7. Discussion

Calibration targets must move to the boundary. All evaluated mechanisms are calibrated on binary distinctions and steepen the severity gradient; sensitive deployments must evaluate L1–L2 explicitly rather than trust L3-derived claims. The cross-modal handoff makes this worse: text filters cannot decode visually adversarial prompts (the stealthiness analysis in Sec. 4.2), and image classifiers trained on explicit L3 content miss L1–L2 violations.

From diagnosis to mitigation. Insight 6 turns the benchmark from a measurement tool into an instrument: LoRA-tuning Qwen2.5-VL-7B on SafeGrad's ladders (Supp. Sec. M) recovers the L1–L2 band zero-shot filters miss, transfers to fresh generations from all six models (pooled FBR 2.4%), and is taxonomy-agnostic (regenerate ladders under one's own policy, retrain). A binary-tuned control (ladder-structure causality), description-only and image-mismatch controls (visual grounding), and description-free operation are future work; the graded labels likewise invite severity-aware defenses (per-rung loss weighting for guidance, severity-stratified erasure for weight editing, graded preference pairs for safety tuning; Tab. 5).

Scope boundaries. Copyright and PID show lower HGR than NSFW categories (Tab. 4): MLLM classifiers are weaker at fine-grained identity harms, so this gap is likely *underestimated*. Severity definitions are Western (US/EU) policy-grounded; a bounded non-Western probe (Supp. Sec. K) quantifies the asymmetry and motivates jurisdiction-calibrated anchors.

8. Limitations

Evaluation scope. T2I models are evaluated with checkers disabled (raw generative risk); defenses are tested only on SD1.4, since weight-editing needs architecture-specific DiT ports.

Coverage. Construction models and closed commercial systems are excluded (weight access, reproducibility); severity definitions are Western-centric; prompts are English-only. Insight 5's universal-filter reading rests on the three generalist judges, since NSFW-targeted filters and single-category detectors (e.g., NudeNet [11]) are out-of-domain on Legal/Social content. The human study uses three annotators; a larger panel and a fully blind harm rating are planned.

Evaluator error. The MLLM evaluator is noisiest at L1 (human $\kappa = 0.73$; guidance-ablation shift $< 2.4\%$). Since it sees sample-specific risk descriptions, absolute HGR figures are protocol-relative (blind ensemble: 7.2% vs. 76.4% guided at L3) and L0 rates are the query's noise floor. The ladder scorer and verifier are Qwen-family, but the cross-family remediation run (InternVL2-8B, Supp. Sec. M: FBR 40.1% $\rightarrow$ 1.3%) shows the tuned filter's transfer is not a same-family teacher artifact. The label-stripping ablation retains sample-specific risk descriptions, so description-cue bias is not fully excluded; an image-grounded audit without them is future work. Image-level SEMs also understate uncertainty (samples within a ladder share a scenario); ladder-level resampling would widen intervals.

9. Conclusion

SafeGrad shows T2I safety evaluation has been measuring the wrong target: mechanisms certify safety at the explicit extreme while deployment risk lives in the L1–L2 regime. Across 6 models, 9 defenses, and 6 filters, attacks exploit this gap structurally, and a ladder-tuned filter closes it to 2.2–2.4% bypass (matched zero-shot anchors 37.5–65.3%): the gap is trainable, not intrinsic. Closing it requires severity-calibrated response across the spectrum, not L3 suppression alone.

Ethical Considerations

SafeGrad involves generating and handling harmful content; it is entirely synthetic, spot-checked for personal information, and human participants (Supp. Sec. E) were informed and could skip any sample. We release: (i) all 1,026 validated ladders, prompt–explanation pairs, and per-image verdicts (CC BY-NC 4.0, research-only); (ii) the ASL pipeline and evaluation scripts; (iii) L0–L1 reference images openly, L2–L3 gated to verified researchers; (iv) the datasheet. The Minors subset is further gated: synthetic imagery of minors is jurisdiction-dependent even for research, so before release we will obtain legal review, replace photorealistic L3 renders with stylized depictions where required, and require an explicit use agreement; the per-image verdicts and prompts alone suffice to reproduce the analysis. We notify affected developers 60 days ahead of release.

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